

New Surge IN KABUL

As America under Obama unfurls a new Afghan strategy, India reorients its focus for a larger role

| By Saurabh Shukla |

Afghanistan is once again in the crosshairs of the world with Barack Obama taking over as the US President and unfurling a whole new American gameplan for the troubled country and the region. Declaring that the war-torn nation would be his top foreign policy priority, Obama announced a surge of troops of over 30,000 soldiers to augment the two lakh US and NATO soldiers currently in Afghanistan in a bid to salvage what is being seen as a losing battle. With the Taliban making a dramatic comeback and Pakistan flagging in its efforts to control its resurgence, the US has appointed Richard Holbrooke as special envoy for Afghanistan and Pakistan. Washington is concerned at the deteriorating situation with Hillary Clinton, the new US secretary of state, describing Afghanistan as a narco-state whose drug trade has ballooned to \$300 million. The country's administration is in shambles, corruption is rife and President Hamid Karzai's writ doesn't seem to run beyond Kabul.

India has been watching the new dynamics unfurl in the region and has been quick to realign its diplomatic compass. With the resurgence of the Taliban posing a threat to India's security, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee used his visit on January 21 for opening the strategic Zaranj-Delaram road — built by India to connect Kabul with Iran — to assess the situation and fine-tune its policy

with the new demands. "We have a commitment to bring peace to Afghanistan which is important for the stability of the entire region," remarked Mukherjee. The 215-km road was the prime target for the Taliban and Pakistan's intelligence agency, the ISI, who tried hard to ensure that it was never completed as it provides Afghanistan an easy transit option straight to the border with Iran. For India too, it opens up a strategic doorway for trade with Central Asia through Iran.

The road is symbolic of how in recent years India has carved out a strategic foothold in Afghanistan with its goodwill diplomacy. New Delhi has pledged over \$1.2 billion (Rs 6,000 crore) and after completing the strategic Zaranj-Delaram highway in south-western Afghanistan, a second major infrastructure project, the Pul-e-Khumri to Kabul transmission line and the sub-station at Chimtala in northern Afghanistan, will be handed over

shortly to the Afghan Government. "Our strategic interest is well-served by stability and peace in Afghanistan and we are working to help the country stand on its own feet," says Indian Ambassador Jayant Prasad.

With India wanting to rejig its Afghan policy, on the agenda is the expansion of the bilateral security rela-



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THE US MAY EXPECT INDIA TO CONTRIBUTE TROOPS BUT EXPERTS WARN AGAINST IT, SAY DEVELOPMENT IS KEY.